This stress response suppresses your immune system and can cause other health problems, including high blood pressure, depression, and anxiety. The relaxation response interrupts this stress response and helps your body return to a state of balance and health.

Reduced anxiety. A study of college students showed that practicing pranayama reduced test anxiety in students. Another study of senior citizens showed reduced anxiety after two months of deep breathing exercises.

Lower blood pressure. Slow deep breathing for five minutes has been shown to lower blood pressure and heart rate in people who practice it.

Improved sleep. One of the negative side effects of stress can be trouble sleeping. It can be almost impossible to fall asleep when your body is caught up in the stress response. Practicing deep, slow breathing techniques such as 4-7-8 breathing can trigger your body's relaxation response and help you get to sleep.

Less pain. A study of 16 healthy people found that those who practiced relaxed deep breathing experienced less pain than those who practiced deep breathing that required a lot of sustained attention. Both groups experienced less tension, anger, and depression.

Better concentration. A 2017 study examined the effect of eight weeks of deep, slow, abdominal breathing on attention, emotions, and stress levels. After training, the people in the deep breathing group performed better on tests of attention and had fewer negative emotions.

How 4-7-8 Breathing and Deep, Slow Breathing Affect Your Body

The sort of deep breathing practiced as part of the 4-7-8 breathing technique helps calm your body by activating your parasympathetic nervous system. Your body's automatic functions, such as your heartbeat and digestion, are controlled by your autonomic nervous system. This system has two parts, the sympathetic nervous system and the parasympathetic nervous system.

The sympathetic nervous system controls your body's stress response. The parasympathetic nervous system controls your body's rest and relaxation response. When you activate one of these, you suppress the other. This is why deep breathing is so effective at causing the relaxation response.

The 4-7-8 breathing technique is one method of deep breathing that you can use to reap such benefits. However, the particular method you use doesn't matter. If the 4-7-8 method doesn't work well for you, you can try another. You should experience the relaxation response with any breathing method that is slow and deep.

Takeaways

The 4-7-8 breathing practice is a type of mindful breathing. It can help you relax and deal with stress. By disrupting the stress response, 4-7-8 breathing can give you other health benefits, including lower blood pressure, better sleep, and lower anxiety.

4-7-8 Breathing FAQs

British Heart Foundation: "3 breathing exercises to relieve stress."

Cleveland Clinic: "How and Why To Try Alternate Nostril Breathing."